



- Photo courtesy of the Carolina Raptor Center

A young Osprey recovering from a gunshot wound, pictured here at the Carolina Raptor Center's hospital, will become a permanent resident of a new Osprey enclosure at the Center.

New bird landing at Raptor Center

BY ELEANOR KENNEDY
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A 2-year-old osprey, flightless from a gunshot wound, is about to get a new name and a new home at the Carolina Raptor Center.

The bird of prey was found shot two years ago in New Mexico. Wildlife rescuers there surgically repaired his wing but said his injuries prevented him from being released back into the wild.

The rescuers sent him to the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville, where work was underway for a new osprey exhibit. This will be the first time the Raptor Center has housed ospreys in more than 20 years, said Michele Houck, the center's community relations director.

Last summer, a group of Piedmont Natural Gas interns cleared the space that will house the new exhibit. In exchange for that help and years of financial and volunteer support, the Raptor Center gave Piedmont naming rights for the new osprey.

To choose the bird's name,

Piedmont held a Facebook contest.

Voting ran for 10 days and 512 votes were cast. The winning name will be revealed at an event for friends and family of the Raptor Center this afternoon.

Houck said Piedmont's involvement with the center is a great model of "corporate stewardship."

"They are really interested in scientific education and the environment," Houck said. "That's a match to Carolina Raptor Center because that's what we do."

Everyone from interns to top-level executives have been involved with the Raptor Center over the years, Houck said.

Ken Valentine, vice president of business development and technology services, is the third Piedmont executive to serve on the Raptor Center board. He said the center is a valuable resource not just for the interesting birds it houses, but also for its educational impact.

"People start to see how everything is connected and you

can't do anything in isolation without any effect on our environment," Valentine said.

Today's event is not public but the exhibit will be open all starting Sunday.

The exhibit will include enclosures: one for the new osprey and one for another rescued osprey named Edward. Edward has already moved into his enclosure, but the new osprey's home won't be ready for him until September.

The exhibit also features an observation deck and walkway resembling a dock in a lakeside setting.

Ospreys are large, fish-eating birds of prey found across the world. Houck said they tend to be nervous birds, making it tough to find ospreys that will interact well with the center's visitors.

But she said Edward and his new friend have the perfect temperament to be "great teachers" to birds.

"This will be a really great thing for Carolina Raptor Center because people really want to see osprey," said Houck.

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